

the OEMs has a different strategy. The retail strategies in China and India are also different. We work with all these OEMs now and the relationship with each one of them is growing. However, we are not announcing any store openings with them.

Q These 850 stores that you are talking about will be Dell and Canonical stores?

No, they are absolutely Dell stores and inside those stores they will be selling machines with Ubuntu pre-installed. The sales people will be trained on Ubuntu. There will be marketing collateral like posters and brochures about Ubuntu, so that the user has information about what to buy.

The changing face of Microsoft...

Q What is your take on Microsoft's open source subsidiary?

I think Microsoft has got a lot smarter and savvier about open source. Canonical has a good relationship with Microsoft. We have recently announced Ubuntu being supported on Azure, Microsoft's cloud. That's a positive relationship. I think, earlier, Microsoft's strategy was based on fear and disdain. Now, they have recognised open source. Previously, they were hoping open source would somehow just go away. But they are smart business people and they know that open source is not going away anywhere. So they are adopting the strategy to figure out how to work together. I think that's a smart business move. They know that their customers want to use Linux and open source. However, I don't see them open-sourcing Windows ever. I don't think Microsoft will ever go to that extreme, but I think they are making pragmatic, realistic, smart business decisions about the fact that people live in a heterogeneous computing environment, and open source and Linux are a part of the IT landscape. They have realised that the better everybody interacts with each other, the better the experience will be for the end user and customers.

"Microsoft doesn't have any intentions of being open source. Microsoft has intentions of meeting their commercial goals, as any company does, including Canonical."

Q Any reasons for joining hands with Microsoft on the Azure platform?

Microsoft's goal with Azure is to provide infrastructure that delivers computing resources and computing power to its users. Azure is the infrastructure piece, and there are guest images and guest OSs that sit on top of that in the cloud. For Microsoft, it's a smart business decision to make sure that

what they are delivering in that cloud is what people want to use. And for us, it's a smart business decision to make sure that people who want to use Ubuntu, even if they want to use it around Windows, can do so in a secure and certified manner. So, it was very obvious that we ought to work with Microsoft to make sure that the Ubuntu that people use in Azure Cloud is the best Ubuntu experience possible. It's what Microsoft's customers want and what our customers want as well. So it was a very natural partnership to strike. I think there is often a perception that there are some backroom deals, but there is none of that in this case. It is a very obvious business decision. The end user wanted to use Ubuntu; we wanted them to use it; Microsoft wanted them to use it on their cloud; so it's a natural alignment of objectives.

Q Even if it was a business decision, Microsoft still sees any other operating system as a competitor...

Similarly, any operating system is a competitor to Ubuntu. People want to use the right tool for the job. I think it's important to be able to compete and co-operate with other companies. Today, with so many big companies with such a range of activities, there is bound to be competition in some areas. I think that's natural. If you allow that competition to stop you working with someone, you will be very isolated. You have to learn to collaborate and compete. Collaboration often makes the competition easier because there is mutual respect from the collaborative efforts and vice versa. By competing, you learn about the others' strengths and you appreciate those strengths sometimes.

Q Does that mean Microsoft was isolated so far and, now, these moves are in the direction of being collaborative?

I think Microsoft is certainly trying to re-establish itself or establish itself with the open source community and with open source advocates. But it is the dominant player. It's not right to say that they are isolated. They are clearly the leading OS in many environments, depending upon how you define those environments. As I said before, it is a pragmatic smart decision of theirs to learn how to work with open source competitors rather than trying to push them away. And in some ways, it's recognition on their part that open source is not going away anywhere. They tried to beat it, but having realised that it is going to be around, they are figuring out how to get the best from it.

Q But what about the secure boot feature of Windows 8 that Microsoft is talking about? There is a lot of opposition to it from The Linux Foundation as well. What is your take on that?

I think there are different aspects to the secure boot issue. At the purely technical level, there are genuine benefits to a secure boot. Then there are some marketing and brand implementations on top of that, which are being driven by competitive concerns rather than any worries about technical security. Stepping in those two areas is difficult, and this is